Center for Bridge Education Newsletter - Spring 2025

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Street Taco Saturdays: A Resounding Success!



Our "Street Taco" bridge teaching and mentoring sessions have been a huge hit! Every Saturday afternoon, kids drop in to play bridge with peers and adult mentors, enjoying free food from CBE. This

year, we added a 10-week series of beginner lessons, taught by experts William Zhu, Chris Chen, and Anant Rathi, which significantly boosted attendance.

The lessons and subsequent coaching sessions have brought in many enthusiastic young players, some of whom will compete in the Youth NABC in Philadelphia this summer. Our kids love these sessions, often playing for hours!

A big thank you to all CBE members and volunteers, including our expert teachers and coaches William Zhu, Chris Chen, and Anant Rathi, as well as mentors Dan Kroll and Deborah Murphy, and occasional guests Amber Lin, Kevin Rosenberg, John and Allison Kranyak, and Sylvia Shi. Your dedication makes this program thrive!



(From left to right) Peter, Nathan, Ivan, and Andrew



(From left to right) Hayden, Anant, Kaitlyn, and Samuel



Peter, Nathan, Ivan, and Andrew and Will



Kristyn, Anson, Chris and Kaitlyn



Peter, Carly and Anant



Chris, Will, Hayden and Carly



Nathan, Peter and Anant

Our Young Stars Compete at Junior USBC

CBE is thrilled to highlight the impressive performance of our young bridge players, Keith, Kyle, Jayson, and Kate, alongside alum Helen, at the 2024 Sam Amer Junior U.S. Bridge Championships in Atlanta. This highly competitive event selected the U.S. teams for the 2025 World Youth Bridge Teams Championships in Salsomaggiore Terme, Italy.

A huge congratulations to CBE alum Helen, who earned a coveted spot on the USA1 U26 (Under 26) Women's team! Also, Jayson and Kate will be representing the USA2 U16 (Under 16) team – an incredible achievement!

CBE veterans Kyle and Keith, though not qualifying for the U21 team this year, played admirably against formidable opponents. These 15 and 17-year-old high school students, mentored by CBE board member

Dan Kroll, demonstrated their talent and passion. We know they have a bright future in bridge ahead!



(From left to right) Kyle, Keith, Ethan and Zach

Pictured below are other Bay Area kids who competed at the Junior USBC trials, including our own CBE veteran Kate (second from left). Both Kate and her brother Jayson secured spots on the USA2 U16 team after grueling matches. Way to go, Kate and Jayson!



(Kate, second from left, with other members of USA1 and USA2 U16 squads, with non-playing coaches Amber Lee and Kevin Rosenberg)



(Jayson, third from left, Kate, far right, and other U16 team trial competitors)

Article contributed by Jayson:

It was the USA U16 Trials, and I was really nervous. The competition began with two intense training days, designed to sharpen our skills and warm us up for trials. We partook in various bidding drills, cardplay sessions, and partnership practices, led by many experienced and famous mentors. One interesting highlight of the practice was a "bidding quiz" where partners independently answered questions about bidding, the goal being to match one another's responses. My partner and I had a decent score, though it definitely revealed our areas for growth. The next few days would begin with two days of qualifying matches for the third day and then the ceremony for who wins would come right after.

When the official trials finally started, I remember walking out of the hotel venue elevator with a mix of energy and anticipation. Friends and competitors from across the country were mingled under one roof ready to fight for the three top spots. This year, qualifications for the USA team were different. The top three pairs would automatically qualify and make the team. However, there are 12 people on USA's two U16 teams, therefore the other 6 players would be selected through a grading process scored by the mentors (the top 6 players not including the 6 automatically qualified would make up the rest of the team).

Once inside the main room, we were directed to our assigned seats in one of the two U16 rooms. The space reminded me of my school during testing time, there were dividers surrounding each tablet and the tablet with your name identified your seat. Then the game began: my partner and I used a precision system I had only learned a year and a half earlier, a decision that carried pressure as a precision system is not recommended. The very first board gave a promising score, yet that success soon led to a series of bad boards, one after another.

By the end of the first day, we found ourselves second-to-last in the rankings. What happened? We had spent hours practicing. We played thousands of boards together and I thought we were one of the stronger pairs at the event. Was it the pressure? Did we not prepare enough? We made mistakes, one after another - communication errors, play mishaps, and many that were preventable. I couldn't believe it. Second-to-last place. We were so upset, we couldn't even speak to each other. I went to bed disappointed while my mentors kept saying, "You can always come back tomorrow."

The next morning during breakfast at the hotel's all-you-can-eat restaurant, my family and I ran into my partner and his dad. We sat down together and his dad started to talk to us about strategies and boards. We had a long way to go if we were to automatically qualify. So that day, we played like we had nothing to lose. Surprisingly, we killed the first session playing like we did. I don't know if it was us playing more freely and naturally, but we did it. During the afternoon, we faced some tough opponents and barely skimmed a slightly above-average score. But, with fingers crossed, we advanced to the qualifying stage in 6th place.

In the morning session of the qualifying stage, we played a below average round, furthering our worry of not qualifying. But in the afternoon of the 3rd day, we played amazing! We scored enough for us not just to move up one place but two places from 6th place, landing us in 4th place! This was an incredible comeback and big improvement from our horrible first day - an initial 11th place standing. Although we did not automatically qualify, my partner and I were two of the six people chosen through the grading process that ultimately secured us spots on USA U16 team 2.

All in all, the experience was a good assessment of a place to grow as the competition really gave us a sense about what we are up against in Italy during the 2025 World Championships. Finally, coming back from second-to-last place in this trial taught me one lesson that I will never forget: Never give up.

Helen Chow Competes at USBC Mixed Teams

In May 2025, CBE alum and board member Helen Chow competed in the USBC Mixed Teams competition in Chicago, vying for a spot at the 2025 World Bridge Team Championships in Herning, Denmark. Helen's team, including Nicole Qian, Steven Wang, Philip Wang, and Ron Smith, reached Stage 2 (Day 5). Way to go (again), Helen and team!



(Helen Chow, far right, with teammates Nicole Qian, Steven Wang, Philip Wang, and Ron Smith)

Article contributed by Helen:

In May, I played in the Mixed event in Chicago. My team was off to a strong start, holding their own against one of the most experienced lineups. One particularly memorable hand was when we stumbled into a grand slam and made it. With a bit of luck on our side, it turned into a funny highlight and plenty of laughs afterward.

While the bridge was fun and competitive, my favorite part of the event was getting to meet and spend time with bridge professionals. The chance to exchange stories and learn from them, especially with Ron Smith as one of my partners, made the experience unforgettable.

CBE Youth Head to YNABC in Philadelphia!

The Youth North American Bridge Championship (YNABC) is set for August 1-2, 2025, in Philadelphia, and CBE will again partially subsidize travel and hotel for kids from our programs who train and attend. As seen in last summer's YNABC triumphs, we fully expect our talented youth to showcase their bridge prowess once more this year!

CBE Kids at Quicktricks

CBE continues its summer tradition of encouraging kids to compete in face-to-face games every Monday night at 6:45 p.m. at Quicktricks, San Francisco's premier bridge club. We help set up partnerships for weekly pairs games—either with other kids or with adult mentors—and form teams of four on the last Monday of each month.

After the games, when time allows, CBE coaches head to "Gyro Xpress" with the kids to discuss hands over garlic fries, offering some "food for thought." We're excited for another summer of productive club games, all in preparation for the Youth NABC in mid-July!

CBE SiVY Summer Tournament

CBE and SiVY (another Bay Area bridge non-profit) are working together to connect kids from the San Francisco and South Bay bridge playing regions. This summer we plan to host another CBE vs SiVY team game (CBE won last summer's similar event!) as a warmup event to the Youth NABC. The event is tentatively scheduled on Saturday, July 5th.

Our Mission

The Center for Bridge Education has been promoting the game of Bridge in the San Francisco Bay Area since 2007. We have dedicated mentors who volunteer their time to teach bridge to youths, whether in person or online. Our current programs include "Street Taco Saturday" lessons and coaching sessions, fostering and organizing the youths' attendance each week at QuickTricks, and sponsoring the kids at the Youth NABC in the summer. CBE also encourages young players to continue their bridge education

in other ways, including starting or joining bridge clubs at their high schools and colleges, as some of our youths have gone on to do.

CBE Thanks You

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